

like journalists themselves) who want the kind of news the press is most pleased to produce: important information about public affairs and serious political analysis, the sort of news that makes the press a vital link in a vibrant democracy. Journalists typically over-estimate the size of this group when asked about the actual composition of their audience, Gans reports (238-39). At the other extreme is the audience journalists are afraid they actually have: a huge mass of faceless viewers and readers whose desires, if catered to, would reduce the role of the journalist to that of a cheap entertainer. This can be safely be considered a mythic construct as well, since, as Gans points out, journalists are quite uninterested in what is actually known about these "cheap" desires and habits (232). Professional newswriters try not to think about the mass audience, says Gans, for they fear its size and power (234).

Conclusion

The result of all this is a peculiar isolation from actual people. The supposed "clients" of a professional press are treated either as an idealized public, interested in "serious" news and educated enough to understand its importance, or, in the alternative, an equally idealized mass of gossip-lovers, easily distracted, who not only fail to appreciate the efforts of a responsible press but threaten its very existence. The goal of professionalism is

to insulate the press from this threat as much as possible, so that the image of a competent and educated public can rule the journalist's imagination and support his self-esteem. Again, what originally creates a professionalized press is the line protecting the editorial workers from the business people, a mythic divider which serves to distinguish the "public" from the masses, public life in general from the harsh conditions of the marketplace, democracy from capitalism, information from entertainment, the gathering of news from the economics of attention, and which, at the deepest level, divides the responsible, serious "adult" self from the pleasure-seeking child self.

In the next chapter we examine two thinkers who refused to make these separations in their thinking about press and public. Walter Lippmann and John Dewey did not try to isolate the public from conditions they thought threatening to its existence. They took into account the transformation of the public realm from an environment in which attention was granted to one where attention had to be gained. This led them to ask how it was possible for the public to have any meaning in an age of mass communications. Among the factors working against the public was the press itself, in particular the way the modern journalist had conceived of his task. Whether or not there was a public became, for

Lippmann and Dewey, an open question, and, given the depth of their insights, a truly interesting question. It is the question we take up next.

its actual public and that public's degraded (and degrading) tastes. Both attitudes were flights from the whole problem of public life in an industrial age, from the question of whether it was possible to inform a modern public, or whether, indeed, a public even existed.

In the next two chapters we examine the work of two writers who took up these questions willingly, subjecting the idea of an informed public to a kind of twentieth century reality test. In doing so they were led to theorize about the nature of modern journalism as well, since both believed the press was the main hope for reversing the decline of public life. Walter Lippmann and John Dewey refused to allow the professional journalist the comfort of assuming his public was out there, waiting for the vital information he had pledged to provide. Instead they insisted that the press come face to face with the conditions undermining a competent and informed public, some of which the press had itself created. Because they expected so much of the press--more, in fact, than journalists expected of themselves--Lippmann and Dewey saw how little the press was doing to improve the conduct of public life. They saw that the press was part of the problem of preserving democracy in a modern environment.

We will begin with Lippmann. His career is without parallel in the American press, his life an extraordinary record of the conflicts which wracked the twentieth century.

Ronald Steel observes in the opening of his biography of Lippmann that a "man whose childhood had been spent learning Latin and Greek by gaslight and riding a goat cart in Central Park lived through the revolutions of psychoanalysis, bolshevism and fascism, nuclear fission, and frenzied nationalism" (xvii). Lippmann began his writing career by applying the recently published theories of Sigmund Freud to political behavior; he ended with bitter denunciations of the Vietnam War. In between he managed to lead the life of an intellectual and a journalist, engaged in events but concerned about ideas, in particular about ideas that would help solve or at least clarify the great political questions the modern democracies faced. Though he had plenty of reasons to do so, Lippmann never lost what Steel identifies as

a conviction that politics mattered, that men could live a life of reason, and that those with special gifts or understanding had a responsibility to do what they could to illuminate the path. (xvii)

These qualities are worth mentioning not to genuflect toward Lippmann but to point out how his special perspective on the press and public evolved. Other men of ideas have had ideas about the press, and other journalists have been concerned--or imagined themselves concerned--about the great questions of war and peace, religion and science, politics and human nature. John Dewey, Robert Park and Max Weber come to mind in the first category; H.L. Mencken and James

Reston in the second. But as a journalist, Lippmann actually wrote books still worth reading on these subjects; and as an intellectual he actually edited a daily newspaper, one of the finest of his time.¹ His daily column was read by millions of ordinary people who depended on Lippmann to tell them what to think. The influence this gave him meant extraordinary access to leaders and events. Walter Lippmann was "the name that opened every door," as a colleague once put it, a man who could not tour Europe without visiting at least two or three heads of state. One does not lead a life like this and develop an ordinary political philosophy. When Lippmann stepped back to ponder a problem, he stepped back from a world which had welcomed him all the way inside. In 1919, for example, he wrote editorials about the Fourteen Points he had earlier helped Woodrow Wilson to draft (Steel 158-9).

Revamping the notion of liberty and the press

It will not be our concern to review Lippmann's life or work as a whole. We are interested specifically in his thoughts on press, public and the problem of preserving democracy in a modern age. That portion of his work begins in 1920 with the publication of Liberty and the News, a monograph on the heightened responsibilities of a modern press. The background to Liberty and the News--indeed, to most, if not all of Lippmann's writings--was the idea of the

What led Lippmann to formulate the problem in this way were the events of World War I, especially the Paris Peace Conference, where the work of propagandists had whipped up the passions of the home populations and prevented statesmen from devising a sane and just peace.² The Great War showed that a new factor, "the manufacture of consent," had entered the triangular relationship between government, press and public. It was now an open question whether "government by consent" could survive, for democracy was more dependent than ever on the integrity of the news columns while the news columns were more subject than ever to sophistry and manipulation. In this sense, wrote Lippmann, "the present crisis of western democracy is a crisis in journalism" (5).

The key insight in Liberty and the News was that the public had been given more power by modern communications and the scale of the Great Society, which no longer allowed leaders to wage war and make peace in isolation from popular sentiment. But this power was difficult to exercise rationally, since the events with which public opinion was concerned were distant and complex. No more than an impression, more or less accurate but always incomplete, could be had of a war unfolding across the ocean. Even for the people closest to the action the war was something of a mystery. Most people think newspaper correspondents have observed the things they write about, Lippmann noted.

Far from it. Nobody, for example, saw this war. Neither the men in the trenches nor the commanding general. The men saw their trenches, their billets,

sometimes they saw an enemy trench, but nobody, unless it be the aviators, saw a battle. What the correspondents saw, occasionally, was the terrain over which a battle had been fought; but what they reported day by day was what they were told at press headquarters, and of that only what they were allowed to tell. (43-4)

Unable to know things first hand, the public had to depend on the press. But the press was itself dependent on official versions of a war that could not be glimpsed in full. The news inevitably suffered, then, not only from the bias of interested parties, but also from the sheer size of the undertaking, the breaking apart of a graspable, manageable reality that could be surveyed from a point above the action. There was no such point--the world had exploded in scale--and so journalists fell back on official statements, authorized versions of an event no one could see whole. The breaking apart of an environment which could be reliably reported also gave propaganda its entry point, for if the true shape of events was impossible to render, people would provide a shape of their own out of ignorance and prejudice. Propaganda picked up where the facts failed, giving the irrational element in the popular mind an institutional basis. This was part of the problem of journalism in a modern environment: the facts were hard to get, but even getting the facts was no guarantee they would be believed. Propaganda could short-circuit the process, putting what people wish to be true ahead of the truth as known. This was especially likely in a democratic society,

where there were few restrictions on what could be put before the public. In an interesting comparison, Lippmann observed that the verdicts of juries--a kind of case-by-case public opinion--are notoriously unreliable, even though a jury benefits from the rules of evidence and standards for discourse which prevail in the speech environment created by a courtroom. In the court of public opinion there are no such standards, no penalties for lying, no presiding judge to rule statements irrelevant or out of order. Moreover, the jury is not "the qualified voters alone," but

everybody who creates public sentiment-- chattering gossips, unscrupulous liars, congenital liars, feeble-minded people, prostitute minds, corrupting agents. (39)

"It is clear," wrote Lippmann, "that in a society where public opinion has become decisive, nothing that counts in the formation of it can really be a matter of indifference" (36). Here was the most important contribution Liberty and the News had to offer: the notion that all public statements were factors in the formation of opinion, not just those of the journalist. The question of "informing the public" thus widened considerably to take in the entire communication environment, of which the press was only a part. Rumor, gossip, stereotype, prejudice, propaganda-- all these contributed to public opinion as well.

Lippmann's retreat into professionalism

This wider view of the matter was incompatible with the professional attitude we surveyed in the previous chapter. Professionalization is a way of localizing the problem of the public in the behavior of journalists, which can then be managed according to professional standards. The assumption is that a code of conduct among journalists can ensure that the press informs the public. In a famous series of Colliers articles published in 1911, Will Irwin gave voice to this common tenet of a professionalized press. A modern society is dependent on the press for its information, Irwin observed.

Axiomatically, then, the quality of news, its freedom from undue bias and taint, is supremely important. Could one slant or taint all news at its source, he would vitiate all public intelligence. Could one raise the standard of all news at its source, he would correspondingly elevate public intelligence. ("What is News?" 16)

What Lippmann had offered in Liberty and the News was a series of complications to Irwin's formula for improving the public mind. There were sources other than news which bear on "public intelligence," Lippman observed. These included rumor, prejudice and the propaganda which played upon them. Moreover, there were severe limitations on the ability of news to give an accurate picture of events. Journalists often relied on second or third hand information and had no way of observing events themselves. Even more troublesome was the rigorous attitude a citizen must have to translate

accurate news into more reliable opinions. One had to be open to new evidence; a sort of scientific spirit, "a unity of method," had to prevail among common citizens for news to improve the quality of public opinion (67, 72). There was no guarantee that such a spirit existed in the mass of citizens. Yet without it, accurate information could not achieve its aim: "the resumption of contact between beliefs and realities," as Lippmann put it. These things were all more problematic, more difficult to achieve, than the raising of standards within the profession of journalism.

And yet professionalism was the very solution Lippmann advanced at the conclusion of his analysis. Journalists should be better trained and their status upgraded, Lippmann argued. Documentation must improve in the news columns, and all articles should be signed so that reporters can be held responsible for their work. Courts of honor might be set up by journalists themselves to prosecute those who abuse the privileges of a free press. Reporting must become more disinterested and scientific (74-85). These suggestions were entirely conventional in comparison to Lippmann's view of the problem. He, too, fell back on the conduct of journalists as the decisive factor in public opinion, even where his own analysis had showed that many other factors were involved. He, too, focused on the content of the news columns--accuracy and fairness being the main issues--when earlier in the book he had shown, first, that news is a very

limited form of knowledge to begin with, and, second, that the conversion of news to sound opinion requires more than sound news. It involves, in fact, the whole process by which humans form a picture of their world, a territory democratic theory had always declined to enter. This would be the direction his interests would take after Liberty and the News (Blum 60). As Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. observes,

Liberty and the News, for all its apprehensions about the actual workings of democracy, preserved the assumption that, given the neutral facts, the people as a whole could be relied on to act rationally. But Lippmann soon found he could not rest comfortably in this assumption. As he gazed out at America in the twenties, he wondered if better reporting would really solve the problem of public confusion and apathy. Was the "news" really enough? (201-2)

Two years later Lippmann gave a decisive answer to that question. In a famous passage near the end of Public Opinion, he wrote that the press

is like the beam of a searchlight that moves restlessly about, bringing one episode and then another out of darkness into vision. Men cannot do the work of the world by this light alone. They cannot govern society by episodes, incidents, eruptions. It is only when they work by a steady light of their own, that the press, when it is turned upon them, reveals a situation intelligible enough for popular decision. The trouble lies deeper than the press, and so does the remedy. (229)

The conviction that "the trouble lies deeper" than the conduct of the press has helped to make Public Opinion a classic of modern political thought. For the press had been traditionally put forward as the solution to every weakness in democratic theory, much as the schools in America have

been offered up as the solution for every social problem. By stating emphatically that the press was not enough, Lippmann removed the key element in an entire edifice of thought surrounding the duties of the citizen in a democracy. A whole world of assumptions about how people form an understanding of public questions then began to collapse, including those of the journalism profession. Commenting on the 1965 re-issuance of the book, German political scientist Elisabeth Noelle-Neumann noted that "without being sensational at all," Public Opinion "is in fact an expose'."

But it is an expose' that runs so contrary to people's natural inclinations about how they wish to see things that now, long after its original publication, it still seems new and, for all practical purposes, still has not been incorporated into intellectual thought. (143)

Let us see how Lippmann went about this reversal of what Noelle-Neumann calls our "natural inclinations."

The press as a medium without a message

It is possible to argue that the central myth on which all other myths of the press are built is that of an unmediated link with the world provided by journalists to audiences. As Dan Schiller observes, "News reports repeatedly claim that, ideally at least, they recount events without the intrusion of value judgments or symbols" (2). In his study of TV news, Edward J. Epstein was startled to

find that television journalists often believe that the news is simply a "mirror" of the world, even though they work in an environment where, through the cutting and editing film, a picture of reality is actively re-arranged to fit some notion of a "good story" (13-25). Note that a mirror is the most negligible medium possible; it reflects everything, distorts nothing. Comparing news to a mirror can easily be dismissed as an overly defensive response to criticism; but to regard what Epstein calls "the mirror metaphor" as merely a rhetorical ploy would be to ignore the persistence of similar notions in press history.

As we saw in the third chapter, the telegraph seemed to promise a means of world-wide unification, a "universal town meeting" conducted through the press. The idea of a "universal town meeting" denies that the newspaper as a medium linking people is also a medium between people, and that it remains between them, substituting common acquaintance with a symbolic world--the news--in place of actual membership in a common world. We have argued that the newspaper brings its readers together only in the most paradoxical fashion, as members of a community that never meets. But the myth of a "universal town meeting" ignores this paradox. The doctrine of objectivity, about which we will have more to say later, offers a similar sort of denial; it is clearly a myth of unmediated communication in which the world can be offered directly, that is,

"objectively," to readers. Finally, there is the "slaying the messenger" myth, in which journalists interpret criticism of the news as a displaced dissatisfaction with the world as it happens to be. Journalists are simply messengers, the news simply a reflection of "the way things are." Again, the assumption is that the world passes through the news in an unmediated way and is offered that way to audiences.

In an interesting essay on the rise of objectivity as a value in journalism, Anthony Smith locates its origins in the use of shorthand to produce verbatim accounts of speeches in the eighteenth century.

Shorthand was the first of that long series of journalistic techniques which at first seemed to promise the reader the complete recovery of some semblance of reality... By presenting the reader with the ipsissima verba [the very words] of a speech, it seemed at first that reporting was capable of providing a true mirror of reality. ("The Long Road to Objectivity and Back" 161)

The ability to create a replica of the event as it actually occurred first gave reporting a special function, Smith says, allowing journalism to separate itself as an art from printing and publishing. From this original division grew the possibility of a reporting profession, he argues. If he is correct, then the "mirror metaphor" is deeply rooted in the very idea of journalism. It is what separates the journalist as a figure from other types of observers, and from other functions inherent in the newspaper.

Mirroring the world is the thing journalists can do that non-journalists cannot; on this original distinction a definition of the press is built. Perhaps this is what accounts for the persistence of objectivity as a principle of journalism, despite the many justifications for abandoning it. In a different context, Smith observes that the idea of objectivity, which, after all, implies a world which can be objectively perceived, was upended by all the developments in modern thought. And yet it had been so institutionalized by journalism schools and professional routines that the wiping away of its intellectual basis did nothing to dislodge objectivity from journalism. "Freud, Einstein, Heisenberg, and all of the twentieth-century movements in the arts and sciences could shift and manipulate the term at will without greatly disturbing the newspaper world," Smith writes.⁴

What could account for the persistence of a world view that apparently has so little going for it? The suggestion here is that objectivity may only be the surface expression of a larger assumption about unmediated communication, the assumption being that journalism as communication can recover the world and deliver it directly to its audience. This idea is more than a professional myth: it creates the press as an institution, marking off the boundary between journalists and non-journalists, the press and the layity. Even those most dissatisfied with the news tend to

employ the mirror analogy in their attacks on the press. They want journalists to be "fair," to tell it like it is, to write and speak the truth. They want journalism to mirror the world. Never do they ask journalists to be better symbol makers or story tellers. There is nothing non-sensical about these expectations, but they do share the assumption that an ideal press is a medium without any message other than the one worldly events have for the life of man. That is the moral of the slaying the messenger tale: the messenger is killed--by non-journalists--because he has no message other than that of events themselves.

The third world of representation

Lippmann's Public Opinion was an open attack on the mirror analogy, an attempt to introduce a contrary idea--namely, that the world cannot be mirrored in the news because it is a joint product of the perceiver and the perceived, both for journalists and, more importantly, for the public. Lippmann insisted on discussing a third realm, a "pseudo-environment," that must always exist between people and events: the world of representation. This third world cannot be eclipsed by fair and complete reporting; it does not dissolve with the ability of photography to reproduce images exactly; it cannot be willed away or minimized in any fashion because it is a fact of human nature, and the first fact of human communication.

For the real environment is altogether too big, too complex, and too fleeting for direct acquaintance. We are not equipped to deal with so much subtlety, so much variety, so many permutations and combinations. And although we have to act in that environment, we have to reconstruct it on a simpler model before we can manage with it. To traverse the world men must have maps of the world. Their persistent difficulty is to secure maps on which their own need, or someone else's need, has not sketched in the coast of Bohemia. (11)

The student of public opinion, Lippmann continued, must recognize at the outset "the triangular relationship between the scene of action, the human picture of that scene, and the human response to that picture working itself out upon the scene of action" (11). Public opinion arises from events and returns to affect them, but the connection is not a direct one. Thus the image of a triangle: the third point is language and the entire problem of representation through symbols. All knowledge is mediated; the only way we learn anything about events is through symbols, and symbols are always a reduction and distortion of what they symbolize. A three-sided model contrasts, of course, with the line or channel that is commonly assumed to stretch from the world to audiences through the press. Having declared this at the outset--"We shall assume that what each man does is based not on direct and certain knowledge, but on pictures made by himself or given to him"--Lippmann then set out to square democratic theory within the triangle of human communication (16). As might be expected the fit was rather poor.

Most of Public Opinion is a series of observations on the limits of human perception in comparison to the reality it confronts, with particular emphasis on political events and the way they are perceived. "For the most part we do not first see, and then define, we define first and then see," Lippmann wrote. "In the great blooming, buzzing confusion of the outer world we pick out what our culture has already defined for us, and we tend to perceive that which we have picked out in the forms stereotyped for us by our culture." These already formed images, "the current patterns, the accepted versions," are a kind of filter through which news of the world passes. They "intercept information on its way to consciousness," forcing the new (and the news) to conform to the familiar (54-57). Lippmann was careful to add that a reliance on what he called "the greater economy of the allegory" was not a weakness or a vice but a human necessity, especially when the mind turns to public affairs: "In putting together our public opinions, not only do we have to picture more space than we can see with our eyes, and more time than we can feel, but we have to describe and judge more people, more actions, more things than we can ever count, or vividly imagine" (95). Again:

So great is the multitude of things that we cannot keep them vividly in mind. Usually, then, we name them, and let the name stand for the whole impression. But a name is porous, old meanings slip out and new ones slip in... (103)

In comparison to the demand for meanings language is static, frozen. There is therefore a structural gap between the play of events and the means available for recognizing and interpreting them. Not only language, but all forms of representation are constantly doing violence to the facts, and this violence is not a willful conspiracy or the result of sloppy speech but a built-in feature of human communication. In addition to these inevitable limits on perception--which could almost be said to be biological--there are social facts which need to be recognized, Lippmann argued. Thought goes on in a "bath of noise" and a host of distractions and amusements confronts the modern citizen (47). The amount of time the average person spends on public affairs is comparatively meager. "We are concerned in public affairs," (that is, they affect us) but "immersed in our private ones" (36). An appetite for the study and discussion of public questions is neither a requirement for voicing an opinion nor a common attribute of those who do. Lippmann had noticed and could not help remarking upon the "relief" that is commonly felt when "talk turns from 'general topics' to a man's hobby" (45). Our private lives are so much more real and immediate; it should not surprise us that they win out over politics in the competition for attention. And yet this fact, obvious to all, is rarely acknowledged in our thinking about public opinion.

Functions of the symbol in politics

To create consent through a common understanding of the facts is all but impossible, Lippmann argued; the facts are distant and complex, the will to understand them slight, the limitations of language too heavy. And yet some sort of agreement, some common ground must be reached for politics to proceed in a democracy. An area of agreement above the plane of events must therefore be secured. This is the function of the symbol in political discourse: to allow masses of people to share an opinion even when they do not share an understanding of the facts. When political reality is reduced to slogans, catch-phrases and iconic images, people respond just as powerfully to the symbol as they do to the conditions it was meant to represent. And the response is often a private one, in the sense that it is based on some emotional need or will to believe that has arisen out of the individual's personal circumstances. Phrases like Law and Order, Justice, Humanity (or, in our own time, Big Government or Welfare Cheat) allow for a unity that would not exist if discussion proceeded at a more concrete level. They literally create out of private feeling "public" opinion. But the public-ness of opinion formed in this way merely indicates the level of abstraction at which political discourse is conducted, not the breadth of agreement a particular leader or campaign has achieved. Lippmann writes,

If, for example, one man dislikes the League [of Nations], another hates Mr. Wilson, and a third fears labor, you may be able to unite them if you can find some symbol which is the antithesis of what they all hate. Suppose that symbol is Americanism. The first man may read it as meaning the preservation of American isolation, or as he may call it, independence; the second as a rejection of a politician who clashes with his idea of what an American president should be, the third as a call to resist revolution. The symbol itself signifies no one thing in particular, but it can be associated with almost anything. And because of that it can become the common bond of common feelings, even though those feelings were originally attached to disparate ideas. (132)

Visual symbols are a particularly potent means of creating this quasi-public consent, for they evoke private feelings in an effective way.

...where action depends on whether a number of people are of one mind, it is probably true that in the first instance no idea is lucid for practical purposes until it has visual or tactile value. But it is also true that no visual idea is significant to us until it has enveloped some stress of our own personality. Until it releases or resists, depresses or enhances, some craving of our own, it remains one of the objects which do not matter. (105)

The art of deploying symbols in politics to find the level of abstraction at which many private feelings begin to meet, and to communicate to large audiences at that level. Employed in this fashion, symbols "do not stand for ideas, but for a sort of truce or junction between ideas. They are like a strategic railroad center where many roads converge regardless of their ultimate origin or their ultimate destination" (133). Those who control these strategic points on the terrain of symbols also control public policy,

Lippmann observed. This is the problem which propaganda and the manufacture of consent pose for democracy: agreement reached in the "pseudo-environment" of representation allows for action at the level of events, but the connection between the two is deranged. Shared symbols do reflect a shared understanding. Public opinion is really private feeling publicly registered. The symbolic environment in which elections are determined and policy debated fails to reflect the "unseen environment" where problems are hidden in a tangle of facts. Only the visible is deemed to be real. As Lippmann observed, "There has always been more popular interest in the profits of millionaires, which are visible but comparatively unimportant, than in the wastes of⁵ the industrial system, which are huge but elusive." Thirty years before television he had recognized the fact that not all dimensions of a problem can be portrayed visually, and yet the visual is deemed the most real.

At the level of symbols the propagandist rules politics; at the level of events the master is the machine politician. A heightened reliance on imagery and an⁶ increasingly remote bureaucracy thus go hand in hand. They are two sides of the same coin: the functional derangement of discourse from policy. The political environment included both these levels--the symbol and the system--but not a means for reconciling them. This was a fact which could not be assimilated into democratic theory, Lippmann charged. Here began the next stage of his argument.

Democracy as second nature

In the opening of the book Lippmann had declared that "instead of taking for granted an environment that is readily known," the student of public opinion is interested in "how the larger political environment is conceived, and how it can be conceived more successfully" (17). This was the question democracy had always avoided. The early democrats, including the founders of the American republic, had assumed that the knowledge needed to govern the world was inborn: "Men took in their facts as they took in the breath" (164). For this assumption to be at all workable, the scope of the world had to be restricted to the dimensions of village life, a conclusion which Jefferson--never a vulgar democrat--had logically drawn. The ideal community in Jefferson's vision, (and in American democratic theory as a whole) is a self-contained agrarian environment, in which the problem of knowledge never arises because the world is so restricted in scale.

It was not that the Founding Fathers were ignorant of facts at odds with this vision. They saw the mobs of the cities, they knew the limitations of the average man's mind, they admitted--some publicly, most privately--the strength of the aristocrat's argument that only an elite were fit to govern.⁷ And there were critics at the time who pointed these things out. But they "were about as welcome as a

small boy with a drum," Lippmann wrote. The democrats saw themselves engaged in a "bitter and uncertain struggle" for human dignity, and had found in the democratic ideal a faith "so much deeper, more intimate and more important" than any practical theory of government (162-3). Unable to reconcile this faith with their knowledge of the world, they searched for a world which would justify their faith, and found it in the self-contained village of the eighteenth century. There was "an element of solid sense" in their reasoning, Lippmann wrote.

Jefferson was right in thinking that a group of independent farmers comes nearer to fulfilling the requirements of spontaneous democracy than any other human society. But if you are to preserve the ideal, you must fence off these ideal communities from the abominations of the world. If the farmers are to manage their own affairs, they must confine their affairs to those they are accustomed to managing. Jefferson drew all these logical conclusions. He disapproved of manufacture, of foreign commerce, and a navy, of intangible forms of property, and in theory of any form of government that was not centered in the small self-governing group. (170)

A vision of a self-contained, naturally knowable and easily managed environment gave rise to a compatible idea of citizenship. Men were assumed to naturally possess the knowledge and practical skills necessary to govern themselves. Citizens were thought to be jacks of all trades who were equally adept at tending their own lives and conducting public business for the good of all. Equally adept also meant equally interested: the average citizen was assumed to be public-spirited by nature, motivated to take

an interest in "everybody's business" since he knew everybody in town (173). Democracy therefore required no particular training or controlled temperment; as a way of life it was neither learned nor earned but granted to man as second nature. This may have been a serviceable set of assumptions in the eighteenth century, Lippmann allowed, but when it was extended into a modern environment it made no sense at all. Summarizing this portion of Lippmann's argument, D. Steven Blum writes,

the notion that citizenship could be mastered effortlessly by all was tenable only, Lippmann asserted, if the boundaries of the self-contained society were enforced ruthlessly, only if the affairs of the community did in truth remain simple and predominately detached from those of the larger world. And it was this pristine state of affairs that was being made obsolete by the complex interdependence of the twentieth century; democracy could no longer be expected to dwell contentedly within its own borders. (68)

The boundaries that had been placed around the community's affairs were clearly dissolved by modern conditions. But the image of citizenship those boundaries helped to create--that of the generally competent, naturally skilled, public spirited man--could not be abandoned, for there was nothing in the ideas of the democrats to take its place. Democractic theory was not, in any sense, learning theory.⁸ And so an ideal of citizenship practical only for a self-contained village was extended to take in the entire world, since in the Great Society the entire world was the domain of public affairs. The reasoning was simple:

Everything was now connected to everything else. Through modern communication every place was now in touch with every place else. Therefore, everyone could now know what was happening to everyone else. The doctrine of "omnicompetence" was born, in which the average citizen was expected to have a working knowledge of all events and an informed opinion on every public question of consequence, even when events unfolded in an unseen and unfamiliar environment.

The unpopularity of a popular press

That we must all be informed about everything was an entirely unworkable ideal, Lippmann concluded; there was nobody, not even an expert, who approximated it. And yet the absorption of the small town into the Great Society had not yielded any other theory of citizenship. Omnicompetence had triumphed by default, a victory Lippmann refused to accept.

There is no prospect in any time which we can conceive, that the whole invisible environment will be so clear to men that they will spontaneously arrive at sound opinions on the whole business of government. And even if there were such a prospect, it is extremely doubtful whether many of us would wish to be bothered... (197)

At this point an obvious question presented itself: what about the press? Is the press not a means for bringing "the whole business of government" within the range of the common citizen? Does it not offer at least the hope of a

reasonably complete picture of the world available to anyone who can read? This was the question Lippmann took up next. But rather than beginning with the promise of the press, which had hypnotized democrats for centuries, he opened his analysis with a more general observation: "The idea that men have to go forth and study the world in order to govern it, has played a very minor part in political thought" (201). To Lippmann this was a startling and deeply revealing fact: we take knowledge of the world for granted. The only barrier to an informed citizenry that is usually acknowledged is censorship, where it is assumed that if the truth is allowed to circulate freely, it will triumph in the minds of men.⁹ That is the closest democracy comes to any kind of learning theory. The insistent belief, said Lippmann, is that the "truth is not earned, but inspired, revealed, supplied gratis" as long as information flows freely through the culture. This very limited conception of how people come to know their world extends to thinking about the press, he wrote.

Universally it is admitted that the press is the chief means of contact with the ~~unseen~~ environment. And practically everywhere it is assumed that the press should do spontaneously for us what primitive democracy imagined each of us could do for himself, that every day and twice a day it will present us with a true picture of all the outer world in which we are interested. (203)

This expectation, that the press will assemble for everyone a reliable image of the world, reflects the

simple-minded view that knowledge need not be earned by study and effort. To make this point Lippmann focused on the economy of the newspaper. We do not expect to pay for our news; instead, we ask advertising to cover the costs of producing a newspaper-- a symbol, Lippmann thought, of the meager amount of effort we are willing to expend on public affairs. The average man "expects the fountains of truth to bubble, but he enters into no contract, legal or moral, involving any risk, cost or trouble to himself. He will pay a nominal price when it suits him, will stop paying whenever it suits him, will turn to another paper when that suits him. Somebody has said quite aptly that the newspaper editor has to be re-elected every day" (203). The citizen takes little responsibility for the press in comparison to other public institutions. Schools are funded directly by taxes voted on by the taxpayers. Utilities are supported by user fees. Law and medicine also charge a fee which the client pays directly. But the costs of the press must be hidden away, dissolved into the price of goods, which includes the expense of the advertisements which make the newspaper a solvent enterprise. (204).

This unusual economy has its warping effects. Although the newspaper is expected to provide the general news upon which a democracy depends, it is not allowed to prosper by providing that news. Maintaining a steady hold on the reader is the only way of succeeding in the newspaper

business; yet the individual reader judges the newspaper not on its general news coverage--which, dealing with distant events, is difficult to evaluate--but on the items of interest to his own life. It is human interest, not social responsibility which spells success in the newspaper world, and to be interesting frequently means flattering a prejudice, distracting a tired mind, indulging an appetite-- in general, turning the newspaper into a fun-house mirror of the reader's own personality. Arthur Brisbane, Hearst's most trusted editor, once made this point in a particular effective way. "Nobody wants to know what you think," said Brisbane. "People want to know what they think" (qtd. in Hughes 42). The newspaper, expected to be the great mirror of events in the external world, is forced to turn back on itself and begin to reflect the characteristics of its readers. Only then can it afford to publish the news which is about events "out there" in the wider environment where public questions unfold. The mirror analogy may be right after all; but, according to Brisbane's logic, the mirror is held up to the audience, not the world. The economy of the newspaper thus prevents it from being fully "about" events in the external environment. In the language of cybernetics, the newspaper must employ the principle of redundancy--repeating what people already know and believe--in order to introduce any information into public affairs.¹⁰

Lippmann's argument was that the low price of the newspaper reflected a lack of effort to learn about the world, which forced the newspaper to devote more and more of its resources to maintaining some sort of hold on the reader.¹¹ This in effect transferred the will to read from the individual reader to the thing read, where it took the form of "human interest" stories and eye-catching design--anything with immediate or natural appeal. To Lippmann this system amounted to a collective refusal of responsibility, an unwillingness to bear the costs of informing ourselves. We do not want to bear the expense, the time and the mental effort it takes to gain a trustworthy picture of the world; and this refusal is one of the factors preventing the newspaper from assembling such a picture. The newspaper was simply not popular enough to support itself, and so it took on other functions totally irrelevant to its mission in order to achieve solvency.¹² Now, here was a view somewhat at odds with common sense. It stood to reason that the huge audiences gained by the mass circulation dailies were a sign of their popularity. Indeed, on the basis of these figures the newspaper began to proclaim itself a "tribune of the people." But to the extent that cheap prices and sensational treatment were responsible for larger sales, there was a sense in which bigger circulations were an index of the newspaper's unpopularity. Because people do not want news enough to pay full price for it, because they do not

want to exert much effort in learning about the world, for these reasons--having to do with the lack of interest in the newspaper--the newspaper puts all its efforts into being interesting. That it often succeeds in the effort does not make the newspaper a popular medium; it simply shows that the technical problem of attracting attention has been solved for the moment. Simple equations between the content of the popular press and "what most people want" are therefore faulty. The formula for the popular newspaper originates in the fact that most people don't want the newspaper enough to pay for it. A truly popular medium--that is, one which the people actively supported--would require neither the subsidy of advertising nor the cheap lure of sensationalism, both of which arise from the absence of interest in the newspaper's primary function: to gather and print news.

News vs. truth

Lippmann's reason for pointing this out was to argue that our "casual relation to the press" reflects a negligible interest in understanding the events about which we are expected to hold opinions (208). Of course, there were other factors as well which prevented the newspaper from fulfilling its sacred functions in a democracy. These had to do with the nature of news. Even assuming an eager citizenry motivated to learn about the world, the newspaper

could not do what it was expected to do: provide a secure understanding of events in the "unseen environment" beyond the reader's locale.

Reporting the news, Lippmann argued, is an activity different from discovering the truth. News and truth are not the same thing, not because the news is inaccurate or inobjective but because news reports are a very limited way of understanding the world. Latent in this argument was a distinction between events and the conditions causing them. News "is not a mirror of social conditions, but the report of an aspect that has obtruded itself" (216). Until some event occurs which can be reported, the forces at work in the world remain beyond the reach of the news. The more points at which underlying conditions can be fixed, measured, dramatized or somehow given manifest form, the more news there can be. But the quality of news--its ability to reflect an unfolding reality--depends on the character of the events which convert underlying conditions into reportable items. Some events are better than others in reflecting the true state of things. Strikes, for example, tend to be stereotyped struggles between management and labor in which the facts at dispute are often themselves in dispute. Much can escape what Lippmann called "the machinery of record," the means by which the current state of things is translated into reportable form. While the machinery of record works well in converting the state of

the stock market into daily prices, or the state of the pennant race into ball scores and standings, it works less well in translating "what is going to happen" into reportable news items today, in converting "states of mind" into a form suitable for the newspapers to report and comment on (217). In short, not everything can be told through the medium of recent events. James Carey re-made this point in a 1974 essay on "Journalism and Criticism." Journalists, he says, "are at a loss for what to do on the days when there isn't any news breaking." Carey continues:

We still do not know how to bring to life the invisible: a slow shift in Black migration patterns out of the South, the relation between grain sales to the Soviet Union and grain elevators failing in small Illinois towns, the significance of the reduction of the birthrate...all these "events" which, because they are not tied to personalities or timeliness, escape daily journalism yet constitute the crucial stories determining our future. (248)

The newspaper offers a disjointed and distorted picture of the world, again, not because the minds of journalists are disjointed or distorted but because the nature of news is to emphasize the episodic, the visible, the dramatic, the stereotypical-- in short, the event rather than the condition causing it. Realizing this bias toward the event, publicity and public relations learned to create events that will get their clients favorable coverage. What these professions had discovered is the element of artifice in the news. Many things that are happening in the world do not take the shape of news "until somebody protests, or somebody

investigates, or somebody publicly, in the etymological meaning of the word, makes an issue of them," wrote Lippmann (emphasis in original; Public Opinion 217). Unfortunately, journalists do not often think about the shaping of events; they hesitate to admit that the news is made.¹³ They are therefore losing ground to professions who suffer no such illusions.

The development of the publicity man is a clear sign that the facts of modern life do not spontaneously take a shape in which they can be known. They must be given a shape by somebody, and since in the daily routine reporters cannot give a shape to facts, and since there is little disinterested organization of intelligence, the need for some formulation is being met by the interested parties. (218)

Lippmann was a great believer in the disinterested fact. He was convinced that "the truth" about social conditions could be had, if only an adequate machinery of record were set up by public-minded agencies having no particular interest in the outcome of the inquiry. He believed, in other words, in social science as a science.¹⁴ But the news could not be that science, for the press was not large enough, rich enough or organized enough to assemble the machinery of record a modern society required. It was not possible for the press to itself make the world intelligible to its citizens. If journalists had a role in the process it was to prod other institutions, especially government, to improve the machinery of record, so that the press would have better, more reliable facts to report. The

press, said Lippmann, "can fight for the extension of reportable truth" (228). But it was ridiculous to expect it to provide the truth about every issue of concern to a democratic nation, for the press

is very much more frail than the democratic theory has as yet admitted. It is too frail to carry the whole burden of popular sovereignty, to supply the truth which democrats hoped was inborn. And when we expect it to supply such a body of truth we employ a misleading standard of judgment. We misunderstand the limited nature of news, the illimitable complexity of society; we overestimate our own endurance, public spirit, and all-round competence. We suppose an appetite for uninteresting truths which is not discovered by any honest analysis of our own tastes. (228)

Lippmann thought we must abandon the hope that the press will make up for the defects in democratic theory, which had never faced the problem of knowledge honestly. In passing from a self-contained village environment to a wider world where events unfold at a distance, democracy failed to ask how the unseen environment could be brought into contact with public opinion. Instead it just shoved the press into the breach between beliefs and realities, expecting it to magically create a responsible citizenry. "The press has often mistakenly pretended that it could do just that," Lippmann added. We thus have unrealistic expectations for public opinion.

The Court of Public Opinion, open day and night, is to lay down the law for everything all the time. It is not workable. And when you consider the nature of news, it is not even thinkable. For the news, as we have seen, is precise in proportion to the precision with which it is recorded. Unless the event is

capable of being named, measured, given shape, made specific, it either fails to take on the character of news, or it is subject to the accidents and prejudices of observation. (229)

Lippmann's solution, then, was to prod government and industry into improving the means by which they name, measure and describe social conditions, and to urge that this inquiry be conducted in a disinterested manner by trained experts. The press would then benefit from these improvements in "organized intelligence," and the news might move closer to the truth. But even this improvement would not make the mystical dream of omniscience a workable reality. An adjustment had to be made in the role ordinary people are asked to play in the settling of public questions. Democracy must give up the "intolerable and unworkable fiction that each of must acquire a competent opinion about all public affairs," Lippmann wrote (19). The idea of an improved machinery of record is therefore "not to burden every citizen with expert opinions on all questions, but to push that burden away from him towards the responsible administrator" (250-1). The disinterested expert will sift through the evidence and the opinion which exists on public issues, and advise the legislature and the executive of his findings. The public would be called on to make a decision only when the facts are all in, the problem is perceived clearly and a concrete choice can be presented. Only at that point does the ordinary citizen, whom Lippmann

labelled an "outsider," take over from the "insider" whose job it is to know. The outsider cannot know the facts himself; he can only insist that certain procedures be followed in obtaining them (252).

Transcending the professional attitude

So runs the argument in Public Opinion. Three years later, in 1925, Lippmann published its sequel, The Phantom Public, which took up in more depth just what the public can be expected to do. Here the verdict is even harsher. Public opinion is "itself an irrational force," said Lippmann, which can at best be placed at the disposal of those with a workable knowledge of social problems. "With the substance of the problem it can do nothing usually but meddle ignorantly or tyrannically," he wrote.

The individual man does not have opinions on all public affairs. He does not know how to direct public affairs. He does not know what is happening, why it is happening, what ought to happen. I cannot imagine how he could know, and there is not the least reason for thinking, as mystical democrats have thought, that the compounding of individual ignorances in masses of people will produce a continuous directing force in public affairs. (39)

The only legitimate function of public opinion is to occasionally come to a Yes or No decision, to support the Ins or the Outs, to buy or to boycott, but never to direct the course of government (57). The job of the public is "not to express its opinions," Lippmann argued, but to line up on one side or the other. We must therefore

abandon the notion that democratic government can be the direct expression of the will of the people. We must abandon the notion that the people govern. Instead we must adopt the theory that, by their occasional mobilizations as a majority, people support or oppose the individuals who actually govern. We must say that the popular will does not direct continuously but that it intervenes occasionally. (62)

The response at the time to Lippmann's analysis can be summarized as follows: enthusiasm and broad agreement over his critique of democratic mythology, (some calling Public Opinion a major advance in political theory) and, at the same time, skepticism and in some cases ridicule toward the solutions offered. Why democracy should trust experts to be any more "disinterested" than ordinary citizens was a question Lippmann had failed to answer. Also, the faith in facts and an improved machinery of record did not seem to be equal to the problem as he had sketched it, leading the Nation to say that, while the observations Lippmann had made about the ordinary citizen were "tragically and obviously true," his suggestions for improving public opinion amounted to "aiming at a conflagration with a squirt gun."¹⁵ Once again his solutions seemed overwhelmed by the depth and clarity of his insights into the defects of democracy.

Still, a genuine advance had been made. As we showed in the previous chapter, in Liberty and the News Lippmann fell back on greater professionalism in the press as the solution to the problem of public opinion in a modern democracy. But he was clearly not satisfied with this

first treatment of the question, so he had another try at it in Public Opinion. There he went beyond the professional attitude--which focuses attention on the proper conduct of journalists--to the way people form a picture of the world outside their immediate environment. This was a key step, for it focused attention on a whole range of issues professionalism had ignored. To show how this is the case is the remaining task of the present chapter. We shall interpret Lippmann's view of press and public in light of the "professional attitude" in journalism.

The key assumption of a professional press is that information made public will mean a public that is informed. The only possible question, then, is the journalist who furnishes the information. Will he be free? If he is free, will he be fair? If fair, accurate? If accurate, complete? When these things are assured, all else follows. The republic is secure if the integrity of its news columns can be maintained. Do we exaggerate? Just such a conclusion is drawn in Joseph Pulitzer's proposal for a school of journalism. Let us quote him at some length and observe the logic unfolding:

The Greeks thought that no republic could be successfully governed if it were too large for all the citizens to come together in one place. The Athenian democracy could all meet in the popular assembly. There public opinion was made, and accordingly as the people listened to a Pericles or to a Cleon the state flourished or declined. The orator that reaches the American democracy is the newspaper. It alone makes it possible to keep the political blood in healthful circulation in the veins

of a continental republic. We have--it is unfortunately true--a few newspapers which advocate dangerous fallacies and falsehoods, appealing to ignorance, to partisanship, to passion, to popular prejudice, to poverty, to hatred of the rich, to socialism, sowing the seeds of discontent--eventually sure, if unchecked, to produce lawlessness and bloodshed. Virtue, said Montesquieu, is the principle of a republic, and therefore a republic, which in its purity is the most desirable of all forms of government, is the hardest of all to preserve. For there is nothing more subject to decay than virtue.

Our Republic and its press will rise or fall together. An able, disinterested, public-spirited press, with trained intelligence to know the right and courage to do it, can preserve that public virtue without which popular government is a sham and a mockery. A cynical, mercenary, demagogic press will produce in time a people as base as itself. The power to mould the future of the Republic will be in the hands of the journalists of future generations. This is why I urge my colleagues to aid the important experiment [in journalism education] which I have ventured to endow. (680)

The line of reasoning runs as follows: The Greeks recognized that the people can rule only if they remain in close contact with one another. Therefore democracy is limited by the factor of distance. But the press wipes out distance as a factor, making possible a republic larger than any the Greeks could imagine. This gives the press tremendous power, which can be used for good or ill depending on the character of the journalist. If the journalist shows virtue the republic will be safe. If the journalist is corrupt the republic will fall. Thus the importance of professional training: on its success rests the future of democracy.

Lippmann interrupted this logic at the point where democracy is extended over distance. As soon as citizens had to deal politically with an "unseen environment," a fundamentally new predicament arose, he contended. The world had to be reduced, summed up, symbolized--in a word, represented--when it could not be experienced directly, and there were a number of difficulties inherent in representation.¹⁶ These became obvious as soon as one looked beyond the conduct of journalists to the way people formed a picture of the world. Here the stereotype was the archtypal case. The trouble with the stereotype was not simply that it reduced and therefore distorted the world, but that it did so according to an existing prejudice or predisposition in the audience, giving to distant events a familiar shape and preventing people from judging each new problem on its own terms.

In Lippmann's treatment, the stereotype is the human organism's way of taming the unfamiliar, much as the neurotic symptom is a way of hanging on to past behavior in the Freudian discourse. Indeed, it was nothing less than a psychology of perception which Lippmann wished to add to democratic theory. According to this psychology, it is the reducing and familiarizing power of the stereotype which characterizes politics conducted across distance, not the enlightening power of information distributed through the press. People bridge the gap between a familiar world and a

distant environment by projecting a familiar image onto the unknown, Lippmann argued. Let us be certain about what this means. The hope of the press has always been to enlarge the reader's world by bringing word of events unfolding in distant places. But that is not how the psychology of perception works, said Lippmann. What people do is shrink the world to make it conform to a known territory. Political behavior proceeds from the inside out, so to speak, rather than the outside in. "For the most part we do not first see, and then define, we define first and then see," he wrote in Public Opinion (55). It may be the intention of the press to broaden the citizen's picture of the world by providing information from an unseen environment. But what actually happens is that the reader reduces the news to make it fit a simplified image that "works" for him. This must be the case given the hugeness of the outer environment and the limited means the average man has for perceiving it. As Lippmann says of the citizen,

What reaches him of public affairs, a few lines of print, some photographs, anecdotes, and some casual experience of his own, he conceives through his set patterns and recreates with his own emotions. He does not take his personal problems as partial samples of the greater environment. He takes his stories of the greater environment as a mimic enlargement of his private life. (111)

Democratic theory had always ignored this possibility, Lippmann charged. The press, clearly capable of distributing information across great distances, had given

rise to a dangerous illusion: that each of us can have a say in every question of public consequence by converting the information in the press into rational opinions. Failing to realize how ludicrous this belief is, we have allowed the problem of knowledge to rest untreated, an achilles heel from which democracy was sure to suffer. Rather than revamp our expectations and create new institutions for recording and studying social forces, we have expected the press to magically cure a deep flaw in democratic theory: its failure to accept any limits on what the average man can know of the world. As a result, the "unseen environment" remained largely unseen. Private feeling substituted for truly "public" opinion. Stray bits of knowledge and the accidents of experience formed the basis of political reasoning, opening the way for the propagandist and publicity man. As D. Steven Blum writes, interpreting Lippmann,

democracy was dangerously vulnerable on account of its desultory habits; if it was willing to accept fragmentary knowledge and secondhand opinion as a substitute for wisdom, and to let the "unseen environment" remain out of view, then it would continue to founder in a quagmire of its own making. For special interests accepted no limitation on their education, on the sophistication with which their aims were pursued. Those whose objective was to wrest the spoils from the commonwealth, to accumulate and aggrandize for exclusively private purposes, did not share democracy's timidity in defending its own best interests. Their appetites were voracious and the skill of their manipulative methods was awesome. Every conceivable enticement, as a consequence, would be placed before the populace to sell it something, to enlist its support for one particularist scheme or the next. (82-3)

This was the warning Lippmann had issued: if those who are "public-minded," including the press, do not wake up to the defects in democratic theory, elements who are merely interested in private gain will capitalize on those defects. By exploiting the machinery of modern communications and their knowledge of human psychology, they will widen the gap between "the world outside and the pictures in our heads" (Public Opinion 3).

Mass Communication and the dissolution of the self

As we saw in the previous chapter, the professional attitude in journalism precluded any concern with these issues. Professionalism draws a limit around the problem of the press, inside of which only questions about the conduct of the journalist are deemed relevant. Questions about the tendencies of the audience are classified as "business" rather than "editorial," and the invisible wall separating one department of the newspaper from another becomes, for the press, the line defining a professional journalist. He was the man who would brook no interference in the news by those with unclean hands, the circulation and advertising types. And yet, as communicators, the men attempting to sell more papers or shoes or oatmeal competed in the same symbolic environment, the same "pseudo-world" of representation, as did the journalist. For that matter so did the public relations man and the propagandist. All

these professions worked a territory located somewhere between "the world outside and the pictures in our heads," as Lippmann had put it, an environment structured by the modern media of communication but structured in people's thoughts and images.

It is difficult to speak about this environment because it is neither entirely public nor entirely private, neither equivalent to the "outside world" nor contained in the individual mind.¹⁷ Attempting to characterize the territory created by fashion, the critic Kennedy Fraser calls it "an amalgam of mental and material-- a miasmic half world where ideas have functions and prices, while objects are hung about with thoughts and dreams" (151). The same qualities have been evoked by Christopher Lasch in his attempt to describe what consumer advertising does to a sense of self. Lasch refers to "the insubstantiality of the external world" in an age of mass produced images.

Commodity production and consumerism alter perceptions not just of the self but of the world outside the self. They create a world of mirrors, insubstantial images, illusions increasingly indistinguishable from reality. The mirror effect makes the subject an object; at the same time, it makes the world of objects an extension or projection of the self. It is misleading to characterize the culture of consumption as a culture dominated by things. The consumer lives in a world that has no objective or independent existence and seems to exist only to gratify or thwart his desires. ("The Minimal Self" 30)

Professional journalists may have wanted a haven from what they saw as the crude demands of a mass readership.

But the advertising and public relations professions, the press agents and circulation managers, wanted no such protection. They willingly took the psychology of perception into account in fashioning their appeals to the audience, giving mass communication the ability to reflect some portion of many selves. Thus, while journalists went off to mirror the world, other communicators were holding a mirror up the audience. The point Lasch wanted to make making about this process is that it helps dissolve the external environment. Looking out at the world through the mass media is not like looking through a window; it is like looking at a window that dimly reflects the image of the looker. What is seen is a shadowy world--half self, half scene--a confused melange of images that is neither a mirror nor a window but a third type of representation we can call mass communication. The principle was expressed by Arthur Brisbane, the man who made Hearst's editorials readable. "Nobody wants to know what you think," said Brisbane, "People want to know what they think." But how did he present people with what they think? By publishing an opinion poll about what most people think? No, by giving the predispositions of readers the form of a newspaper editorial, so that the reader's inclinations, once personal and private, could take public form. Giving people "what they think" was not a matter of fashioning an object which represented common opinion but of merging the subject into

the representation. This was the art of Brisbane's editorials. By reading one of them you discovered what you thought; you recognized yourself. What Lippmann called the stereotype worked in a similar way: the popular image or slogan gave public form to a point of convergence among many selves. This process developed from an art to something like a science with the onset of market research in the twentieth century.

Mass communication, then, institutionalizes the original defect Lippmann saw in democracy: the fact that, confronted with the gap between "the world outside and the pictures in our heads" people refashioned the world to make it fit a familiar picture. Democracy did this at the level of theory by projecting a notion of citizenship appropriate only to a village environment onto a complex and interdependent world. Individuals did this in their own behavior by taking the public world as a "mimic enlargement of their private life," as Lippmann put it. In the twentieth century mass communication became the social structure sponsoring this kind of projection, with market research as its quasi-scientific basis. The newspaper, of course, was heavily involved with these developments. Not only was it the place where mass advertising originated; but the newspaper's success in exploiting "human interest" for its circulation value was the original act of mass communication, defined here not by the size of the audience

but by the "feedback loop" which allows receivers of messages to send messages to the newspaper about what messages to send. In a practical sense the object of such a loop is to sell more papers or products or, in the case of today's media campaign, to get more votes. But the effect of the process is much broader: it is to collapse the boundary between "the world outside and the pictures in our heads" by constantly aiming pictures from our heads at us as if they were the world outside. That, after all, is what "image management" is about: a successful image aims back at the audience what it would like to see in a candidate, or pop star or corporation.¹⁸ The effect is to blur the boundary between subject and object, since the image is partly "about" the audience whose urges have created it. The popular image as purveyed through the mass media is the most paradoxical of objects, for it is always part subject. Perhaps this is why soap opera viewers write letters to actors berating them for things their characters did on the show. It is not the difference between actor and role that is forgotten, but the distinction between the character on television and one's own character, the world on the soap and one's own world.

Objectivity as epistemology

Now, in the face of these facts, which concern the "insubstantiality of the external world," as Lasch phrased it, what is the meaning of "objective journalism?" The world which one is to be objective about is under attack: mass communication is out to dissolve it into the self, which has become a commodity in its own right, that is, something to be mass produced.¹⁹ Similarly, the "public" for a public relations man is an unformed thing, a force to be given shape by his own exertions; and "public opinion" is a product to be manufactured.²⁰ What objectivity became in journalism is a way of bracketing or containing this entire problem. The objective existence of events was taken for granted, as was the public. With these two solid anchors assumed at the outset the only thing in doubt was the journalist's objectivity in negotiating between one pole and the other. As sociologists Molotch and Lester observe, the assumption underlying objectivity in journalism is

that there is indeed a world "out there" and that an account of a given event reflects that world, with some degree of accuracy. The "objective assumption" states not that the media are objective, but that there is a world out there to be objective about.
(53)

In saying that mass communication challenged this assumption we are not attempting to escape into solipsism. There is no point in denying that things happen in the world

outside people's imaginations. The question is, how do we characterize the world with which journalism must deal? Is it primarily the world of physical forces and objects? Or is it the world of reports and representations, symbols and language? What exactly is the press doing when it fashions its reports of the world? Mark Fishman takes up this question in considering the nature of a "crime wave."

The media were both the means by which anyone in New York "knew" about the crime wave and the means by which the crime wave was assembled. News organizations created the wave, not in the sense that they invented crimes, but in the sense that they gave a determinant form and content to all the incidents they reported. Out of newswork arose a phenomenon transcending the individual happenings which were its constituent parts. A crime wave is a "thing" in public consciousness which organizes people's perception of an aspect of their community. It was this thing that the media created. (10-11)

Fishman is arguing that journalism is always involved in producing the events it reports. Why? Not because journalists are liars and fabricators, but because an event like a "crime wave" takes place in the world of symbols and perceptions, a world which has no existence independent of the way it is represented. What are called "the issues" have a similar sort of existence. An issue is not a set of physical conditions but the organized perception of a problem that has moved into the political arena. The issues may be about the world, but they are not "in" the world in the sense that an earthquake is. The press often has the job of organizing perceptions into political issues; in

effect it "produces" the issues not by dreaming them up but by concentrating attention in one spot rather than another. When the press says, as it did in 1980, that Chappaquiddick is going to be an issue in Edward Kennedy's Presidential campaign, it is not making a statement about the world but declaring its own intentions as an arranger of perception. Epistemologically, "the issues" are a different order of event when compared to something like the weather, the stock market or the previous night's ballgames.

The conventions of objectivity often fail to recognize this fact. In this sense they obscure the problem of representation as discussed by Lippmann. As a medium the objective news story has a bias; it attempts to convert every sort of event into one which "happened" in the world the way a rainstorm or robbery happens. Only then can the news be purged of "opinion" and the integrity of the journalist assured. Now, there is a trick to this epistemological transformation. The trick is to quote official statements about that aspect of events--namely, their meaning--which does not occur in the same sense that a train wreck or a baseball game occurs. Failing that, one can at least attribute different aspects of an event to vague sources whose only identity is that they are not the writer of the story. "Critics say...", a routine phrase in newswriting, is a barely disguised method of introducing an interpretation. But even in this relatively transparent

example, the effect is to convert what "critics say" into a reportable fact-- the fact that critics say it. Much of the work of journalism is of this kind. Reporters ask spokesmen and authorities for their views, which are converted into a kind of second-level event--the statement--which can then be accurately (or inaccurately) reported.²¹ By this method interpretations are magically given the status of facts: the fact that X said this and Y, his opponent, said that. The problem, of course, is that a linguistic statement does not "happen" in the same way that a tornado happens. The main difference is that a linguistic statement can take its perceiver into account--indeed, it must do so--while a tornado is neutral with respect to the perceiver.

This is such a commonplace in journalism that its significance can easily be overlooked. Everyone knows that, in fashioning a statement, a man being quoted by the press is using his knowledge of the press, of the likely audience for the statement and of the culture as a whole in shaping his reply. In this sense the event is partly determined, or caused, by the very system deploying it as news of the world. A certain redundancy enters the relationship between news and events; journalists are continually getting back as content the forms they have invented. Thus, a spokesman for the Interior Department will claim that the Reagan Administration is totally dedicated to preserving the environment; while the leader of an environmental group will

say that Reagan is totally committed to exploiting the environment for material wealth. These statements mirror the bias of the objective news story as a form, in which opposing views are thought to match and balance each other and thus, in some unexplained way, produce the truth by the symmetry of their opposition. Journalists are continually frustrated by the lack of candor, the exaggeration and predictability of the statements that are given to them. And yet the objective news story has helped to produce this form of talk by implying that extreme conflict between views--supporters say this, opponents say the opposite--somehow adds up to the truth, or at least the opportunity for perceiving it. It never seems to occur to the press that it is simply getting back the bias of its own objective news format. Instead, bias is thought to be exclusively located in the people with whom the press deals.

The real problem is that the statements of authorities and spokesman who are trained to deal with the press are routinely presented as naturally occurring events which must be reported because they "happened." But they did not just happen; they were produced in part by the routines of journalists, just as terrorism is an offshoot of media coverage. What is really happening is that the professional routines of the press are being exploited by those who have learned how the system works. Control over the news has passed into the hands of the officials and experts, those

Fishman calls "authorized knowers," who accomplish the epistimological conversion that is at the root of objectivity. Sociologist Bernard Roscho captured the absurdities of the quotation game in this lament from an editor of the St. Louis Post-Dispatch:

Here is a lie. I know it is a lie, but I must print it because it is spoken by a prominent public official. The public official's name and position make the lie news. Were the sources some unknown person, I could and would gladly throw it in the wastebasket. I have done what I can to show that I know the statement is untrue by putting it under a small headline and printing only enough of it to make an entry in the record of the day's news. Printing these lies, even in this way, is one of the hardest things I have to do. (qtd. in Roscho 50)

Let us recount an extraordinary turn of events. The long fight for freedom of the press was gradually concluded with the triumph of the commercial newspaper. There then began the fight of reporters and editors within the newspaper for freedom from the pressures of the market, the very arena within which the press had gained its independence in the first place. This is the movement we have identified with the professional attitude. The crowning achievement of this movement is the routinization of virtue and character through the instrument of the objective news story. But the objective news story is so oddly fitted to the nature of journalism that it ends up enslaving the journalist to the experts and officials who must constantly be quoted in order to convert²² interpretations into reportable facts. This is the way

the professional journalist solves a fundamental epistemological problem-- the fact that the realm in which the journalist dwells is primarily one of meanings and perceptions, representations of events, rather than the realm of objects and physical forces. The solution objectivity offers is to convert one realm into the other through the trick of quotation and attribution, thus preserving the professional journalist's character, now equated with accuracy, fairness and balance. But a drastic price is paid: somehow the journalist has invented a system which forces him to print lies, even when he knows they are lies. Freedom of the press has thus vanished from the place where it seemed to be safely ensconced: the professional newsroom. "Here is a lie," said the knowing editor, "but I must print it because it is spoken by a prominent public official."

The trick does not work. Interpretations are not converted into facts but frequently into lies. Even worse, the illusion the trick of objectivity offers is unconvincing. Journalists know they are being used, and their professional pride must certainly suffer for it. Consider, then, the ironies in the tale. If lies must be printed, then the man who prints them has certainly lost what we would ordinarily construe as freedom of the press. But to what has this freedom been lost? Not to a ruthless tyrant or a greedy businessman, but to the very system the

journalist has invented. Freedom of the press has vanished from a profession devoted to its principles. So, for that matter, has the element of professionalism. In no sense can the journalist be considered a self-governing professional if his own routines force him to print statements he knows to be false and would rather not print. What a weird turn of events: a free press, professionalized under the rubric of objectivity, holds itself captive to officials and experts, thereby ruining all three goals of freedom, professionalism and objectivity.

Summary

How did this situation come about? The point we have been trying to make in the last two chapters is that the crucial step, from which the press has yet to recover, was the separation of the press as an institution from the newspaper as a means of gaining attention. What Walter Lippman added to this was a theory of origins. The professional attitude in journalism--which focuses the entire problem of public life on the conduct of the journalist--only recapitulates an original defect in democratic theory: the failure to account for the way in which people, not journalists, form their picture of the world. The press was merely participating in a long tradition of ignorance and avoidance when it sought to isolate itself from the means by which attention was gained.

Objectivity emerged as a mechanism by which the press could achieve this isolation and yet be said to be serving the public interest. For the objective journalist does his job by refusing any responsibility for how people come to an understanding of their environment, by, in effect, ignoring the argument sketched in Public Opinion. The objective news story says to the audience "get both sides and decide for yourself," which leaves to the journalist the apparently simple task of presenting both sides. The lesson Lippmann had for the press was that "get both sides and decide for yourself" is not an account of human behavior; it does not describe how people bridge the gap between an unseen environment and a world they know by experience. He proposed a radically different formula for how public opinion is made: "For the most part we do not first see, and then define, we define first and then see." As if this were not trouble enough for the journalist's professional model, there was the added factor of those other communicators--advertisers, press agents, propagandists--who did not play by the same rules as a scrupulous press. Their motto was not "get both sides and decide for yourself" but "let's get the self on our side." Showing no pretense of objectivity, they set out to dissolve the audience into the act of communication and blur the boundaries between subject and object. And these other communicators helped create the environment within which the press had to operate.

What we are describing here is a functional gap between the objective news story and the realities of political behavior, and, at a deeper level, between the assumptions of a professional press and the logic of twentieth century communications. The press contends that furnishing information will lead to an informed public. But the logic of the mass media is to employ an opposite principle: redundancy, the re-presentation of what people already believe, enjoy and expect. The press takes for granted the world outside, on the one hand, and the audience or public, on the other. But the effect of mass communication is to dissolve the environment into the audience to create a shadowy world of images increasingly indistinguishable from the self. The press assumes the objective existence of events "out there" in the world. But to other communicators, especially those that deal with press, events are to be structured, the world is to be arranged, in order to get favorable news coverage. This is the point made vividly in Daniel Boorstin 1961 book, The Image, which introduces the notion of the "pseudo-event," that is, an event created to be reported. Of course the practice of creating pseudo-events was introduced much earlier, with the rise of the press agent and a self-conscious profession of public relations after World War I. But the point is an important one: while journalists attempt to assemble objective accounts of events "out there" beyond the

newsroom, related professions such as public relations and publicity are creating the events journalists are to be objective about. And, of course, they are giving those events a certain shape. The newsroom has been invaded, not by publishers and business managers, but by other communicators who have learned how to exploit the routines of journalists.

Conclusion: McCarthyism as a crisis in public life

Perhaps the most effective deployer of the pseudo-event ever, at least in America, was Senator Joseph McCarthy (Boorstin 21-23). The manipulation of the press by McCarthy shows how deep the gap can be between the assumptions of the professional journalist and the realities of communication in a modern political environment. McCarthy, writes Richard Rovere, "knew the newspapermen and how they worked and what they needed and when their deadlines were and what made a 'lead,' and what made an 'overnight,' and what made a 'sidebar'" (162). In addition to this practical knowledge of how a professionalized press operated, McCarthy grasped intuitively that an outpouring of lies was easier to put over than one or two, that as long as he could attract attention to himself every day the gaps and reversals in his charges would cease to make a difference. He knew also that whether or not Smith was a member of the communist party was not as important as the fact that a United States Senator

had said Smith was. McCarthyism was in large part an exploitation of the weaknesses in the objective news story: its disjointedness, its spurious conversion of interpretations into facts, its total dependence on the pronouncements of authorities, its inability to recognize a statement made with the prejudices and predilections of the audience in mind. The facts were against McCarthy, but facticity--the bias of the objective news story--was entirely on his side. Rovere concludes that McCarthy's

whole approach made it, on the one hand, practically impossible for the press to deny him publicity-- and, on the other, impossible for it to provide for its readers any comprehensible accounting of the ratio of truth to falsehood in what he was saying. (139-40)

McCarthyism overwhelmed the technology of the press. Although there was ample criticism of his crusade, and thus some opportunity to "get both sides and decide for yourself," his ability to get and hold attention proved more important. McCarthy's success in manipulating the press did not go unnoticed at the time; and soon after it forced a wave of anxiety over the weaknesses of objectivity. "Interpretation" became the password of a professionalized press awakened to its own helplessness. This reform movement proceeded entirely within the conventions we have identified with professionalism. The problem was confined to the way in which journalists arranged the facts in their news stories. "Interpretation" ended up meaning the right of the journalist to counter a false or misleading statement

with other information which suggested a different conclusion (Roscho 52). The reliance on the statements of authorities remained intact, although there was widespread discomfort with it. There was no attempt to examine the nature of the public the press was presumably addressing, or the communication environment as a system that included the press. It was assumed that if the objective news story could be tinkered with, the information necessary to prevent another McCarthy would be furnished to the public. This information, facts countering lies, would offset the attention a demagogue was certain to get, the press²³ believed.

Had there been the inclination, McCarthyism might have signified something much deeper to the press: the loss of "contact between beliefs and realities," as Lippmann had once phrased it. It could have signaled a crisis, not just in the routines of objectivity, but in the whole character of public life, in the entire system by which a democracy conducted its public discourse. For McCarthyism proved that "the facts" made small headway against a demagogue armed with the machinery of mass communication. But to give McCarthyism such a meaning might have meant asking, "is there a public?"-- a question the press was organized to avoid. For John Dewey this was the pre-eminent question. Modern conditions threw into doubt the very existence of the public, Dewey believed; and so he endeavored to describe

what a modern public would be like, if indeed it did exist. An examination of his views will shed further light on the limitations of the professional attitude in journalism. That is the task we take up in the next chapter.